Main Idea of a Paragraph

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Functional English (SS1012)

Main Ideas

- Recognizing the main idea, or point, is the most important key to good comprehension.

WHAT IS THE MAIN IDEA?

- To find the main idea, or point, in a reading selection, ask yourself:

"What is the main point the author is trying to make?"


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"I've got problems. I lost my job. My wife left me. My friends don't return my phone calls. Even my dog won't go for a walk with me."

- The main idea, or point, in the cartoon—**that the man on the couch has problems**—is well supported by the statements about his job, wife, friends, and dog.

Read this paragraph, asking yourself, "What is the author's point?"

- Many people feel that violence on television is harmless entertainment. However, we now know that TV violence does affect people in negative ways. One study showed that frequent TV watchers are more fearful and suspicious of others. They try to protect themselves from the outside world with extra locks on the doors, alarm systems, guard dogs, and guns. In addition, that same study showed that heavy TV watchers are less upset about real-life violence than non-TV watchers. It seems that the constant violence they see on TV makes them less sensitive to the real thing. Another study, of a group of children, found that TV violence increases aggressive behavior. Children who watched violent shows were more willing to hurt another child in games where they were given a choice between helping and hurting. They were also more likely to select toy weapons over other kinds of playthings

Which general statement is supported by the other material in the passage?

- **A.** Many people feel that violence on television is harmless entertainment.
- **B.** However, we now know that TV violence does affect people in negative ways.
- **C.** One study showed that frequent TV watchers are more fearful and suspicious of others.
- **D.** They try to protect themselves from the outside world with extra locks on the doors, alarm systems, guard dogs, and guns.

- **A. Many people feel that violence on television is harmless entertainment.**

(The paragraph does not support the idea that TV violence is harmless. Sentence A introduces the topic of TV violence.)

- **B. However, we now know that TV violence does affect people in negative ways.**

(This is a general statement. The rest of the passage goes on to describe three negative ways that TV violence affects people.)

- **C. One study showed that frequent TV watchers are more fearful and suspicious of others**.

(This sentence is about only one study. It is not general enough to include the other studies cited in the paragraph.)

- **D. They try to protect themselves from the outside world with extra locks on the doors, alarm systems, guard dogs, and guns.**

(This sentence provides detailed evidence for the first supporting idea. It does not cover the rest of the paragraph.)

ANSWER

- A. Many people feel that violence on television is harmless entertainment.
- **B. However, we now know that TV violence does affect people in negative ways.**
- C. One study showed that frequent TV watchers are more fearful and suspicious of others.
- D. They try to protect themselves from the outside world with extra locks on the doors, alarm systems, guard dogs, and guns.

WHAT IS THE MAIN IDEA?

The Main Idea as an "Umbrella" Idea



- The main idea is the author's general point.
- The other material of the paragraph fits under the general point.

Main Idea can be:

- STATED: The **Stated Main Idea** is one that is clearly stated in any one sentence in a passage.
- IMPLIED: The **Implied Main Idea** is one that is NOT clearly stated in any one sentence in a passage. It is only suggested or inferred by the supporting details. The author doesn't state it directly.

Where can Main Idea be Found?

- When the main idea of a paragraph is stated, it is most often found in the first sentence of the paragraph. However, the main idea may be found in any sentence of the paragraph.
- The main idea may also be stated in the first sentence of a paragraph and then be repeated or restated at the end of the paragraph.

Implied Main Idea

- The **Implied Main Idea** is one that is NOT clearly stated in any one sentence in a passage. It is only suggested or inferred by the supporting details. The author doesn't state it directly.

RECOGNIZING A MAIN IDEA

- • To recognize the main idea of a passage, you must think as you read.

Here are three strategies that will help you find the main idea:

- **1. Look for general versus specific ideas.**
- **2. Use the topic to lead you to the main idea.**
- **3. Use key words to lead you to the main idea.**

1 Look for General versus Specific Ideas

- In the list of words below, which three items are specific ideas, and which item is the general idea?

  - A. dishonesty
  - B. greed
  - C. bad qualities
  - D. selfishness

Specific ⇨ **A.** dishonesty

Specific ⇨ **B.** greed

General ⇨ **C.** bad qualities

Specific ⇨ **D.** selfishness

Explanation

Bad qualities is the **general idea**. It includes three **specific** types of bad qualities: dishonesty, greed, and selfishness.

Look again at the paragraph on TV violence. Notice that the general idea is supported by specific ideas.

Many people feel that violence on television is harmless entertainment. However, we now know that TV violence does affect people in negative ways. [⇦ **general idea**] One study showed that frequent TV watchers are more fearful and suspicious of others. [⇦ **specific idea**] They try to protect themselves from the outside world with extra locks on the doors, alarm systems, guard dogs, and guns. In addition, that same study showed that heavy TV watchers are less upset about real-life violence than non-TV watchers. [⇦ **specific idea**] It seems that the constant violence they see on TV makes them less sensitive to the real thing. Another study, of a group of children, found that TV violence increases aggressive behavior. [⇦ **specific idea**] Children who watched violent shows were more willing to hurt another child in games where they were given a choice between helping and hurting. They were also more likely to select toy weapons over other kinds of playthings.

2. Use the Topic to Lead You to the Main Idea

- • The **topic** is the general subject of a reading selection.
- • Knowing the **topic** can help you find the writer's **main point** about that topic.

- To find the topic of a selection, ask yourself: **Who or what is the selection about?**
- After you find the topic, ask yourself: **What main point is the author making about the topic?**

What is the topic of the paragraph?

- Recently a family of four were found dead in their suburban home in New Jersey—victims of carbon monoxide. Such cases are tragically common. Carbon monoxide is deadly for many reasons. To begin with, it is created in the most ordinary of ways—by the burning of wood, coal, or petroleum products. Once created, this gas is impossible to detect without instruments; it is colorless, odorless, and tasteless. Also, carbon monoxide mingles with and remains in the air rather than rising and being carried away by the wind. Then, when people unsuspectingly breathe it in, it chokes them, taking the place of the oxygen in their blood. Furthermore, it can do its lethal work in very small quantities: anyone exposed to air that is just 1 percent carbon monoxide for even a few minutes will almost certainly die.

What is the topic of the paragraph?
Carbon monoxide

Recently a family of four were found dead in their suburban home in New Jersey—victims of **carbon monoxide**. Such cases are tragically common. **Carbon monoxide** is deadly for many reasons. To begin with, it is created in the most ordinary of ways—by the burning of wood, coal, or petroleum products. Once created, this gas is impossible to detect without instruments; it is colorless, odorless, and tasteless. Also, **carbon monoxide** mingles with and remains in the air rather than rising and being carried away by the wind. Then, when people unsuspectingly breathe it in, it chokes them, taking the place of the oxygen in their blood. Furthermore, it can do its lethal work in very small quantities: anyone exposed to air that is just 1 percent **carbon monoxide** for even a few minutes will almost certainly die.

Main Idea: **Carbon monoxide** is deadly for many reasons.

3 Find and Use Key Words to Lead You to the Main Idea

- Sometimes an author announces the main idea by using **key words**.
- One group of key words is **list words**. List words tell you that a **list of items** will follow.

- The main idea in the paragraph about carbon monoxide was stated like this:
- Carbon monoxide is deadly for **many reasons.**

The expression **many reasons** suggests that the paragraph may be about specific reasons that carbon monoxide is deadly. The ***list words*** **many reasons** help you identify the main idea.

List Words

several kinds (or ways) of	several causes of	some factors in
three advantages of	five steps	among the results
various reasons for	a number of effects	a series of

Notice that each has a word that ends in **s**. The plural suggests that the supporting details will be a list of items.

Find the Location of the Main Idea

- For shy people, simply attending class can be stressful. Several strategies, though, can lessen the trauma of attending class for shy people. Shy students should time their arrival to coincide with that of most other class members—about two minutes before the class is scheduled to begin. If they arrive too early, they may be seen sitting alone or, even worse, actually forced to talk with another early arrival. If they arrive late, all eyes will be upon them. Before heading to class, the shy student should dress in the least conspicuous manner possible—say, in the blue jeans, sweatshirt, and sneakers that 99.9 percent of their classmates wear. That way they won't stand out from everyone else. They should take a seat near the back of the room. But they shouldn't sit at the very back, since instructors sometimes make a point of calling on students there.

Location of the Main Idea: At the Beginning

- For shy people, simply attending class can be stressful. **Several strategies, though, can lessen the trauma of attending class for shy people.** Shy students should time their arrival to coincide with that of most other class members—about two minutes before the class is scheduled to begin. If they arrive too early, they may be seen sitting alone or, even worse, actually forced to talk with another early arrival. If they arrive late, all eyes will be upon them. Before heading to class, the shy student should dress in the least conspicuous manner possible—say, in the blue jeans, sweatshirt, and sneakers that 99.9 percent of their classmates wear. That way they won't stand out from everyone else. They should take a seat near the back of the room. But they shouldn't sit at the very back, since instructors sometimes make a point of calling on students there.

Find the Location of the Main Idea

- Only about 1 percent of insect species are destructive to crops and property. Nevertheless, this small group causes several billion dollars of damage each year in the United States alone. Harmful insects include household pests, such as termites; crop and livestock pests, such as boll weevils; and hosts of disease-causing organisms, such as mosquitoes infected with parasitic protozoa. Many insects, on the other hand, are beneficial to human society. Some insects pollinate fruit trees, flowers, and many field crops. Bees produce honey and beeswax, silkworms form cocoons from which silk is spun, and lac insects provide the raw material for commercial shellac. Some kinds of insects are natural enemies of destructive insects. For example, the larvae of certain wasps feed on caterpillars that destroy plants. Clearly, insects are both harmful and beneficial to human society.

Location of the Main Idea: At the End

- Only about 1 percent of insect species are destructive to crops and property. Nevertheless, this small group causes several billion dollars of damage each year in the United States alone. Harmful insects include household pests, such as termites; crop and livestock pests, such as boll weevils; and hosts of disease-causing organisms, such as mosquitoes infected with parasitic protozoa. Many insects, on the other hand, are beneficial to human society. Some insects pollinate fruit trees, flowers, and many field crops. Bees produce honey and beeswax, silkworms form cocoons from which silk is spun, and lac insects provide the raw material for commercial shellac. Some kinds of insects are natural enemies of destructive insects. For example, the larvae of certain wasps feed on caterpillars that destroy plants. **Clearly, insects are both harmful and beneficial to human society.**

Find the Main Idea

Do you wear glasses? Make sure your glasses fit well. The earpieces should be at eye level. Don't try to adjust the earpieces yourself. Take your glasses for adjustments to the place you bought them. Keep your glasses in a case when you're not wearing them. This will prevent scratches. Keep the lenses clean. A soft cloth is best for cleaning.

Location of the Main Idea:

Do you wear glasses? Make sure your glasses fit well. The earpieces should be at eye level. Don't try to adjust the earpieces yourself. Take your glasses for adjustments to the place you bought them. Keep your glasses in a case when you're not wearing them. This will prevent scratches. Keep the lenses clean. A soft cloth is best for cleaning.

Location of the Main Idea: Implied Main Idea

Do you wear glasses? Make sure your glasses fit well. The earpieces should be at eye level. Don't try to adjust the earpieces yourself. Take your glasses for adjustments to the place you bought them. Keep your glasses in a case when you're not wearing them. This will prevent scratches. Keep the lenses clean. A soft cloth is best for cleaning.

(The main idea is implied. All of the sentences in the paragraph give details about a main idea. In this paragraph the implied main idea is that taking care of your glasses involves many steps.)